

# Voter Resentment and the Strategic Dynamics of Enfranchisement

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# 1 Model

We analyze a two-period game,  $t \in \{1, 2\}$ , between two political parties,  $A$  and  $B$ . In each period  $t$ , one party is the incumbent, denoted  $I_t \in \{A, B\}$ . The incumbent controls the decision on enfranchisement of a specific group of voters. We let party  $A$  be the incumbent in the first period ( $I_1 = A$ ) and take  $A$  to be the party that enters the game carrying a record of obstruction toward the potential voters. This is the empirically relevant configuration: the incumbent who decides whether to extend the franchise is typically the party with a prior exclusionary history.<sup>1</sup>

The electorate consists of two groups: core voters, constituting a measure  $1 - \lambda$  of the total, and potential voters, constituting a measure  $\lambda$ , where  $\lambda \in [0, 1]$ . The allegiance of core voters is fixed: a share  $\gamma$  of them supports Party A, and the complementary share  $1 - \gamma$  supports Party B. The parameter  $\gamma$  thus quantifies Party A's established partisan strength among core voters. Potential voters, if enfranchised, cast their vote based on a latent signal  $\theta_t \in [0, 1]$ , drawn i.i.d. from a uniform distribution  $U[0, 1]$  in each period  $t$ . A higher  $\theta_t$  indicates stronger support for Party A among potential voters. Both parties observe  $\theta_t$  at the start of each period  $t$ .

The state variable  $E_t \in \{0, 1\}$  tracks the enfranchisement of potential voters, where  $E_t = 1$  if they have been enfranchised in any period  $k < t$ , and  $E_t = 0$  otherwise. At the beginning of the game, potential voters are disenfranchised ( $E_1 = 0$ ). If potential voters are not yet enfranchised at the start of period  $t$  ( $E_t = 0$ ), the incumbent party  $I_t$  decides whether or not to enfranchise them,  $e_t \in \{0, 1\}$ , where  $e_t = 1$  represents enfranchisement and  $e_t = 0$  represents non-enfranchisement. Once enfranchised, voters remain enfranchised in all subsequent periods. Formally,  $E_{t+1} = \max(E_t, e_t)$  for  $t = 0$ , with  $E_0 = 0$ . If all voters are enfranchised in period  $t$  ( $E_t = 1$ ), the game ends.

## 1.1 Resentment

A core feature of our model is the resentment that potential voters hold toward parties that have historically obstructed their enfranchisement. We model resentment as a pair of state variables  $r_t^A, r_t^B \in [0, 1]$ , where  $r_t^i$  records the hostility of potential voters toward party  $i$  at the start of period  $t$ . Resentment toward a party accumulates whenever that party, as incumbent, declines to enfranchise:

$$r_{t+1}^i = r_t^i + \beta (1 - r_t^i) \mathbb{I}_{\{I_t=i \wedge E_t=0 \wedge e_t=0\}}, \quad i \in \{A, B\}, \quad (1)$$

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<sup>1</sup>Once resentment is asymmetric (Assumption 1 below), the choice of which party is the period 1 incumbent is no longer without loss of generality; we select the substantively relevant case.

where  $\beta \in (0, 1]$  governs how an additional act of obstruction deepens resentment. Each electoral period of disenfranchisement moves resentment a fraction  $\beta$  of the remaining distance toward its upper bound of 1; enfranchisement halts further accumulation but does not erase resentment already accrued.

**Assumption 1.** *At the start of the game,  $r_1^A = r_A \in (0, 1)$  and  $r_1^B = 0$ .*

footnote It does not allow us to consider instances in which, for instance, a new party with no political history is less culpable for disenfranchisement than the opposition. We leave the investigation of such cases to future work.

The assumption breaks the symmetry between the parties: at the outset, potential voters resent  $A$  but not  $B$ . The baseline in which resentment is generated entirely within the game is the special case  $r_A \rightarrow 0$  and  $\beta = 1$ , where a single act of obstruction by  $A$  generates maximal resentment,  $r_2^A = 1$ .

XXXXXXXXXXXX Assumption 1 captures the common situation in which the group seeking the franchise has a history of exclusion at the hands of the incumbent that predates the decision modeled here. The groups at the center of the franchise extensions we study (Black Americans, women, and the propertyless) accumulated grievances over decades of obstruction before any particular enfranchisement decision. The assumption breaks the symmetry between the parties: at the outset, potential voters resent  $A$  but not  $B$ . The baseline in which resentment is generated entirely within the game is the special case  $r_A \rightarrow 0$  and  $\beta = 1$ , where a single act of obstruction by  $A$  generates maximal resentment,  $r_2^A = 1$ . XXXXXX Because  $B$  has no opportunity to obstruct, except possibly in the terminal period (period 2, when  $I_2 = B$  and  $E_2 = 0$ ), and a terminal obstruction carries no further electoral consequence,  $r_t^B = 0$  throughout. It is therefore convenient to record the two resentment levels that  $A$  can confront in period 2: following a first-period enfranchisement the stock persists at  $r_A$ , whereas following a first-period obstruction it rises to

$$\bar{r}_A := r_A + \beta(1 - r_A), \quad r_A < \bar{r}_A \leq 1, \quad (2)$$

so that  $r_2^A = r_A$  if  $e_1 = 1$  and  $r_2^A = \bar{r}_A$  if  $e_1 = 0$ .

## 1.2 Voting and Election Outcome

At the end of each period  $t$ , an election takes place. The voting behavior of core voters is exogenously fixed, and potential voters participate if and only if they are enfranchised (i.e.,  $e_t = 1$  or  $E_t = 1$ ).

Should potential voters be enfranchised, the share of them supporting Party A, denoted  $s_t^A \in [0, 1]$ , is a convex combination of their intrinsic preference and a resentment-adjusted preference. This support is a function of the realized signal  $\theta_t \sim U[0, 1]$ , the current resentment levels  $r_t^A$  and  $r_t^B$ , and a parameter  $\alpha \in [0, 1]$  capturing the sensitivity of potential voters to past disenfranchisement. The sensitivity parameter  $\alpha$  quantifies the weight potential voters place on historical conduct relative to their intrinsic preference  $\theta_t$ . If  $\alpha = 0$ , past conduct is irrelevant and  $s_t^A = \theta_t$ . As  $\alpha$  increases, voters place greater weight on the resentment component, and a higher  $r_t^A$ , other things being equal, reduces the share supporting Party A. Formally,

$$s_t^A = (1 - \alpha) \theta_t + \alpha (\theta_t (1 - r_t^A) + (1 - \theta_t) r_t^B), \quad (3)$$

$$s_t^B = (1 - \alpha) (1 - \theta_t) + \alpha (\theta_t r_t^A + (1 - \theta_t) (1 - r_t^B)). \quad (4)$$

It is immediate that  $s_t^A + s_t^B = 1$  for any  $(r_t^A, r_t^B) \in [0, 1]^2$ ; the enfranchised group is fully allocated between the parties.

Under Assumption 1,  $r_t^B = 0$  and the support function reduces to

$$s_t^A = \theta_t (1 - \alpha r_t^A), \quad (5)$$

so that resentment scales down Party A's support in proportion to both its salience  $\alpha$  and its accumulated level  $r_t^A$ . On the path where A enfranchises,  $r_t^A = r_A$  in both periods and  $s_t^A = \theta_t (1 - \alpha r_A)$ . On the path where A obstructs in period 1 and the group is enfranchised in period 2,  $r_2^A = \bar{r}_A$  and  $s_2^A = \theta_2 (1 - \alpha \bar{r}_A)$ .

The total vote for Party A is  $V_t^A = \gamma \cdot (1 - \lambda) + \max\{e_t, E_t\} \cdot \lambda \cdot s_t^A$ , and for Party B is  $V_t^B = (1 - \gamma) \cdot (1 - \lambda) + \max\{e_t, E_t\} \cdot \lambda \cdot s_t^B$ . Party A wins the election with probability  $p(V_t^A, V_t^B) = V_t^A / (V_t^A + V_t^B)$ , and Party B wins with the complementary probability. Since vote shares sum to one,  $p(V_t^A, V_t^B) = V_t^A$ ; when potential voters do not vote this is  $\gamma$ , and when they do it is  $(1 - \lambda)\gamma + \lambda s_t^A$ . The winner of the period 1 election becomes the incumbent  $I_2$  for the second period.

### 1.3 Payoffs and Timing

Each party seeks to maximize the expected discounted probability of holding office. Winning the election yields a flow utility  $R > 0$ , and the future is discounted by  $\delta \in (0, 1)$ . The total utility for party  $i$  is

$$u_i = \sum_{t=1}^2 \delta^{t-1} \cdot R \cdot \mathbb{I}_{I_{t+1}=i}, \quad (6)$$

where the incumbent is determined by the outcome of the election in period  $t$ . The timing within period  $t$  is as follows.

1. State  $(I_t, E_t, r_t^A, r_t^B)$  is known.  $\theta_t$  is drawn and observed.
2. Incumbent  $I_t$  chooses  $e_t \in \{0, 1\}$ . If  $E_t = 1$ ,  $e_t = 1$ .
3. Election occurs, and the winner determines  $I_{t+1}$ .
4. State variables  $E_{t+1}, r_{t+1}^A, r_{t+1}^B$  update according to  $E_{t+1} = \max(E_t, e_t)$  and [\(1\)](#).
5. Payoffs for period  $t$  are realized. The game ends if  $t = 2$ .

## 1.4 Equilibrium Characterization

The model admits a unique Subgame Perfect Nash Equilibrium. Because the incumbent observes the realization of  $\theta_t$  before choosing  $e_t$ , her problem in each period reduces to comparing the electoral value of an enfranchised group, given current resentment, against the value of preserving the core-voter status quo. The support of an enfranchised group is monotone in  $\theta_t$ : a higher realization raises Party A's vote share and lowers Party B's, so enfranchisement becomes more attractive to A, and less attractive to B, as  $\theta_t$  increases. This monotonicity delivers a cutoff characterization of equilibrium behavior. Each party enfranchises precisely when the signal is favorable to it: Party A extends the franchise for high realizations of  $\theta_t$ , whereas Party B – which can only hold the franchise decision in period 2, after a first-period obstruction by A – extends it for low realizations. [Proposition 1](#) formalizes this strategy.

**Proposition 1.** *For each period  $t$  and each incumbent, there exists a unique threshold  $\theta_t^*(\alpha, \gamma)$ , which also depends on the resentment stock and, for  $t = 1$ , on  $\delta$ , such that Party A enfranchises ( $e_t = 1$ ) if and only if  $\theta_t \geq \theta_t^*(\alpha, \gamma)$ , and Party B enfranchises if and only if  $\theta_t < \theta_t^*(\alpha, \gamma)$ .*

*Proof.* See [Appendix A](#). □

Note that when  $\theta_t^*(\alpha, \gamma) \leq 0$  or  $\theta_t^*(\alpha, \gamma) \geq 1$ , the incumbent's decision is unconditional on  $\theta_t$  with former implying Party A always enfranchises while Party B never does. Both parties employ the same threshold following the constant-sum structure of the election. Vote shares sum to one and the win probability equals Party A's vote share; the gain to A from enfranchising in period 2 is, thus, exactly B's loss. This property rests on three features: the constant-sum election, the terminal nature of the period 2 decision, and purely office-motivated parties.

A central feature of the equilibrium is that an increase in voter resentment sensitivity  $\alpha$  has a non-monotonic effect on the incumbent Party A's first-period enfranchisement decision ( $e_1 = 1$ ). This effect is contingent upon Party A's initial partisan advantage among core voters,  $\gamma$ .

**Proposition 2.** *When  $r_A < \frac{\delta\beta}{2(1+\delta)+\delta\beta}$  there exists a unique partisan strength threshold  $\gamma^*(\alpha) \in [0, 1]$  such that the enfranchisement threshold  $\theta_1^*$  is strictly decreasing in the resentment sensitivity  $\alpha$  for  $\gamma < \gamma^*(\alpha)$ , and strictly increasing in  $\alpha$  for  $\gamma > \gamma^*(\alpha)$ .*

*Proof.* See Appendix B. □

The intuition underlying Proposition 2 rests on two countervailing effects of  $\alpha$  on Party A's intertemporal optimization problem. Consider Party A's choice of first-period enfranchisement,  $e_1 \in \{0, 1\}$ , when it holds office in Period 1. A decision not to enfranchise in Period 1 ( $e_1 = 0$ ) causes the potential voters' resentment stock to accumulate from its baseline  $r_A$  to a strictly higher level  $\bar{r}_A$ . Should potential voters be enfranchised in Period 2 — whether by Party A or by Party B — a higher sensitivity  $\alpha$  strictly magnifies the electoral penalty Party A incurs from this newly accumulated hostility. This creates a dynamic incentive for Party A to enfranchise preemptively in Period 1 ( $e_1 = 1$ ) in order to halt the accumulation of resentment and cap it at  $r_A$ . We refer to this mechanism as the *preemption effect* of resentment sensitivity.

There is also a countervailing force, which we term the *entrenchment effect*. Because potential voters enter the game with a preexisting baseline resentment  $r_A$ , enfranchising them today means immediately introducing a bloc of voters whose support for Party A is already scaled down by  $\alpha$ . By increasing the immediate electoral penalty associated with bringing an aggrieved group into the electorate, a higher  $\alpha$  makes first-period enfranchisement intrinsically more costly. Consequently, Party A recognizes that enfranchising resentful voters dilutes its established advantage, reinforcing the incentive to block suffrage today.

The relative strength of Party A's core support, captured by  $\gamma$ , determines which effect dominates. When  $\gamma < \gamma^*(\alpha)$ , Party A is electorally vulnerable; it cannot confidently rely on its core voters alone to deliver electoral success in Period 2. In this case, the preemption effect prevails: securing future support from potential voters is critical, and the party cannot afford to face a resentful voting bloc in the future — especially knowing Party B will eagerly enfranchise them to weaponize that hostility. As a result, increases in  $\alpha$  make the future threat so severe that they strengthen the incentive to enfranchise in Period 1, pushing the threshold  $\theta_1^*$  strictly down.

Conversely, for an insulated party with a strong partisan base ( $\gamma > \gamma^*(\alpha)$ ), an increase in  $\alpha$  reinforces the incentive to disenfranchise. With such a strong core base, Party A has a high

probability of winning without ever needing the potential voters. Increases in  $\alpha$  scales down the support Party A can extract from the enfranchised group in every period. For a strong party, the path on which  $A$  disenfranchises is largely insulated from this force:  $A$  retains office with high probability and, at the period 2, never re-engages the resentful group. The path on which  $A$  enfranchises, however, is not: the grievance  $r_A$  persists even after inclusion and every future election is discounted by  $\alpha$ . An increase in salience, thus, erodes the only path on which it matters, pushing the threshold  $\theta_1^*$  up.

Figure ?? depicts the ex ante probability of first-period enfranchisement as a function of resentment sensitivity,  $\alpha$ , across varying levels of partisan advantage,  $\gamma$ , and visually captures the divergent incentives identified in Proposition 2. For sufficiently weak parties increases in sensitivity  $\alpha$  are associated with decreases in the enfranchisement threshold and thus increases in the likelihood of enfranchisement; preemption dominates. But for sufficiently strong parties increases in sensitivity are associated with higher thresholds and decreases in the likelihood of enfranchisement; entrenchment dominates.

**Proposition 3.** *Maintain  $r_A < \frac{\delta\beta}{2+2\delta+\delta\beta}$ . Let  $\gamma^*(\alpha)$  be the threshold of Proposition 2. Then*

i.  $\frac{\partial \gamma^*}{\partial \alpha} \leq 0$ ;

ii.  $\frac{\partial \gamma^*}{\partial r_A} < 0$ ;

iii. For all  $\alpha \in (0, 1)$ ,

$$1 > \gamma^*(\alpha) \geq 1 - \frac{2(1+\delta)r_A}{2r_A + \delta\beta(1-r_A)},$$

thus  $\lim_{r_A \rightarrow 0} \gamma^*(\alpha) = 1$ .

*Proof.* See Appendix C. □

## 2 Uncertainty

The preceding analysis characterized the equilibrium under the assumption that parties possess perfect information about the latent partisan alignment,  $\theta_t$ , of potential voters. While this allows us to isolate the core strategic incentives, political actors in reality operate under significant uncertainty, forming beliefs from imperfect signals like polling data. To explore the implications of such informational frictions, we now relax the perfect information assumption.

Specifically, assume that parties do not observe  $\theta_t$  directly and instead share a common public signal  $\eta_t$ , which can be interpreted as the number of supporters for Party A in a survey of  $N$  potential voters. This signal is drawn from a binomial distribution  $\eta_t \sim \text{Binomial}(N, \theta_t)$ .

Given a uniform prior for  $\theta_t$ , the shared posterior belief after observing  $\eta_t$  is given by a Beta distribution:

$$\theta_t | \eta_t \sim \text{Beta}(\eta_t + 1, N - \eta_t + 1). \quad (7)$$

This framework nests the complete-information model as a limit case. Let  $\hat{\theta}_t(\eta_t) := \mathbb{E}[\theta_t | \eta_t] = \frac{\eta_t + 1}{N + 2}$  denote the posterior mean. Because the parties' expected utilities are linear in  $\theta_t$ , they evaluate their electoral prospects using this posterior mean. As the signal's precision increases (as  $N \rightarrow \infty$ ), this posterior mean converges in probability to the true latent alignment  $\theta_t$ .

We now show that the core strategic trade-off from our baseline model is robust to this informational friction, although its nature is now mediated by the quality of information.

## A Proposition 1

We solve the game by backward induction. Because the electorate is fully allocated between the two parties, the election is constant-sum:

$$V_t^A + V_t^B = 1.$$

A party's probability of winning the election exactly equals its expected vote share. Thus, maximizing the expected discounted probability of holding office is strictly equivalent to maximizing expected vote share.

In the terminal period  $t = 2$  if the potential voters are not yet enfranchised ( $E_2 = 0$ ), the incumbent  $I_2 \in \{A, B\}$  must choose  $e_2 \in \{0, 1\}$ . If Party A is the incumbent, it chooses  $e_2 = 1$  if and only if the resulting vote share weakly exceeds the status quo

$$\begin{aligned} V_2^A(e_2 = 1) \geq V_2^A(e_2 = 0) &\Leftrightarrow (1 - \lambda)\gamma + \lambda\theta_2(1 - \alpha r_2^A) \geq \gamma \\ \Leftrightarrow \lambda\theta_2(1 - \alpha r_2^A) \geq \lambda\gamma &\Leftrightarrow \theta_2 \geq \tilde{\theta}_2(\alpha, \gamma) \equiv \frac{\gamma}{1 - \alpha r_2^A}. \end{aligned}$$

Because  $\theta_2$  must be drawn from  $U[0, 1]$ , the true equilibrium threshold  $\theta_2^*$  is bounded on the interval  $[0, 1]$ . Formally,  $\theta_2^* = \min \left\{ 1, \tilde{\theta}_2(\alpha, \gamma) \right\}$ . Party A enfranchises if and only if  $\theta_2 \geq \theta_2^*$ . If Party B is the incumbent, it seeks to maximize  $V_2^B$ , which is strictly equivalent to minimizing  $V_2^A$ . Therefore, Party B enfranchises if and only if  $V_2^A(1) < V_2^A(0)$ , or, equivalently,  $\theta_2 < \theta_2^*$ .

We now proceed to  $t = 1$ . Let  $W_i(e_1)$  denote the expected total discounted utility for

party  $i \in \{A, B\}$ . For Party A:

$$W_A(e_1) = V_1^A(e_1) + \delta \mathbb{E}[V_2^A \mid e_1]$$

Party A chooses  $e_1 = 1$  if and only if  $W_A(1) - W_A(0) \geq 0$ . Substituting the period 1 vote shares we get:

$$\lambda \theta_1(1 - \alpha r_A) - \lambda \gamma + \delta(\mathbb{E}[V_2^A \mid E_2 = 1] - \mathbb{E}[V_2^A \mid E_2 = 0]) \geq 0$$

Because  $\mathbb{E}[V_2^A \mid E_2 = 0]$  depends on whether the period 2 threshold  $\theta_2^*$  is interior or at a corner, the unconstrained period 1 threshold,  $\tilde{\theta}_1(\alpha, \gamma)$ , takes a piecewise form.

**Case I:** Suppose  $\gamma < 1 - \alpha \bar{r}_A$ ,  $\theta_2^* \in (0, 1)$ . Evaluating the expected continuation value under  $E_2 = 0$  we get

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{E}[V_2^A \mid E_2 = 0] &= \gamma \mathbb{E}[V_2^A \mid I_2 = A] + (1 - \gamma) \mathbb{E}[V_2^A \mid I_2 = B] \\ &= \gamma + \lambda(1 - \alpha \bar{r}_A) \left( \gamma \int \tilde{\theta}_2^1(\theta_2 - \tilde{\theta}_2) d\theta_2 + (1 - \gamma) \int_0^{\tilde{\theta}_2} (\theta_2 - \tilde{\theta}_2) d\theta_2 \right) \end{aligned}$$

Integrating and substituting  $\tilde{\theta}_2 = \frac{\gamma}{1 - \alpha \bar{r}_A}$ :

$$\mathbb{E}[V_2^A \mid E_2 = 0] = \gamma + \frac{\lambda \gamma}{2(1 - \alpha \bar{r}_A)} ((1 - \alpha \bar{r}_A)^2 - 2\gamma(1 - \alpha \bar{r}_A) - \gamma(2\gamma - 1)).$$

Substituting both expected values back into the Period 1 indifference condition and solving for  $\theta_1$  isolates  $\tilde{\theta}_1$

$$\tilde{\theta}_1(\alpha, \gamma) = -\frac{\delta}{2} + \frac{\gamma}{1 - \alpha r_A} + \frac{\delta \gamma ((1 - \alpha \bar{r}_A)^2 + 2(1 - \gamma)(1 - \alpha \bar{r}_A) + \gamma(2\gamma - 1))}{2(1 - \alpha \bar{r}_A)(1 - \alpha r_A)}.$$

**Case II:** Suppose  $\gamma \geq 1 - \alpha \bar{r}_A$ ,  $\theta_2^* = 1$ . Party A never enfranchises in period 2, and Party B always does.

$$\mathbb{E}[V_2^A \mid I_2 = A] = \gamma, \quad \mathbb{E}[V_2^A \mid I_2 = B] = (1 - \lambda)\gamma + \frac{\lambda}{2}(1 - \alpha \bar{r}_A)$$

$$\mathbb{E}[V_2^A \mid E_2 = 0] = \gamma - \lambda\gamma(1 - \gamma) + \frac{\lambda}{2}(1 - \gamma)(1 - \alpha \bar{r}_A)$$

Substituting this back into the indifference condition we get

$$\tilde{\theta}_1(\alpha, \gamma) = -\frac{\delta}{2} + \frac{\gamma}{1 - \alpha r_A} + \frac{\delta((1 - \alpha \bar{r}_A)(1 - \gamma) + 2\gamma^2)}{2(1 - \alpha r_A)}.$$

Because the realized signal  $\theta_1$  is constrained to the unit interval, the true equilibrium threshold is bounded

$$\theta_1^*(\alpha, \gamma) = \max \left\{ 0, \min \left\{ 1, \tilde{\theta}_1(\alpha, \gamma) \right\} \right\}. \quad (8)$$

When  $\tilde{\theta}_1 \leq 0$ , the future continuation value dominates and Party A always enfranchises; if  $\tilde{\theta}_1 \geq 1$ , the risk of oppositional voting dominates and Party A never enfranchises. In the interior where  $\tilde{\theta}_1 \in (0, 1)$ , Party A enfranchises conditionally if and only if  $\theta_1 \geq \theta_1^*$ .

Finally, because the game is zero-sum in electoral probabilities, Party B's expected total utility is inverse:  $W_B(e_1) = 1 + \delta - W_A(e_1)$ . If Party B were the incumbent, it would choose  $e_1 = 1$  if and only if  $W_B(1) - W_B(0) > 0$ . This simplifies directly to  $W_A(1) - W_A(0) < 0$ , the exact logical negation of Party A's condition. Therefore, Party B enfranchises if and only if  $\theta_1 < \theta_1^*(\alpha, \gamma)$ .

## B Proposition 2

We analyze the unconstrained threshold  $\tilde{\theta}_1(\alpha, \gamma)$  derived in Appendix A. Because the equilibrium threshold is bounded as  $\theta_1^* = \max\{0, \min\{1, \tilde{\theta}_1\}\}$ , strict monotonicity of  $\tilde{\theta}_1$  transfers directly to  $\theta_1^*$  wherever  $\tilde{\theta}_1 \in (0, 1)$ , holding weakly at the boundaries. We restrict attention to  $\gamma \in (0, 1]$  since  $\tilde{\theta}_1(\alpha, 0) \equiv -\frac{\delta}{2}$ . We differentiate  $\tilde{\theta}_1$  wrt  $\alpha$  across two cases.

**Case I:** Suppose  $\gamma \geq 1 - \alpha\bar{r}_A$ . Then

$$\tilde{\theta}_1(\alpha, \gamma) = -\frac{\delta}{2} + \frac{1}{1 - \alpha r_A} \left( \gamma + \frac{\delta}{2} ((1 - \alpha\bar{r}_A)(1 - \gamma) + 2\gamma^2) \right).$$

Derivate wrt  $\alpha$

$$\frac{\partial \tilde{\theta}_1}{\partial \alpha} = \frac{N(\gamma)}{(1 - \alpha r_A)^2},$$

where

$$\begin{aligned} N(\gamma) &\equiv (1 - \alpha r_A) \left( -\frac{\delta\bar{r}_A}{2}(1 - \gamma) \right) + r_A \left( \gamma + \frac{\delta}{2} ((1 - \alpha\bar{r}_A)(1 - \gamma) + 2\gamma^2) \right) \\ &= \delta r_A \gamma^2 + r_A \gamma - \frac{\delta(\bar{r}_A - r_A)}{2}(1 - \gamma). \end{aligned} \quad (9)$$

**Case II:** Suppose  $\gamma < 1 - \alpha\bar{r}_A$ . Then

$$\tilde{\theta}_1(\alpha, \gamma) = -\frac{\delta}{2} + \frac{\gamma}{1 - \alpha r_A} + \frac{\delta\gamma((1 - \alpha\bar{r}_A)^2 + 2(1 - \gamma)(1 - \alpha\bar{r}_A) + \gamma(2\gamma - 1))}{2(1 - \alpha\bar{r}_A)(1 - \alpha r_A)}$$

and

$$\frac{\partial \tilde{\theta}_1}{\partial \alpha} = \frac{\gamma \cdot P(\gamma; \alpha)}{2(1 - \alpha r_A)^2(1 - \alpha \bar{r}_A)^2},$$

where

$$P(\gamma; \alpha) \equiv 2\delta(r_A(1 - \alpha \bar{r}_A) + \bar{r}_A(1 - \alpha r_A))\gamma^2 - \delta(r_A(1 - \alpha \bar{r}_A) + \bar{r}_A(1 - \alpha r_A) + 2r_A(1 - \alpha \bar{r}_A)^2)\gamma + (1 - \alpha \bar{r}_A)^2(2(1 + \delta)r_A - \delta(\bar{r}_A - r_A)). \quad (10)$$

Because  $\bar{r}_A - r_A = \beta(1 - r_A) > 0$ ,  $N(\gamma)$  is strictly convex with  $N(0) = -\frac{\delta}{2}\beta(1 - r_A) < 0$  and  $N(1) = (1 + \delta)r_A > 0$ . Thus,  $N(\gamma)$  crosses zero exactly once, and has a unique root  $\gamma_N \in (0, 1)$  such that  $N(\gamma) < 0$  for  $\gamma < \gamma_N$  and  $N(\gamma) > 0$  for  $\gamma > \gamma_N$ . Unique positive root  $\gamma_N \in (0, 1)$  of this quadratic formula is

$$\gamma_N = \frac{-\left(r_A + \frac{\delta\beta(1-r_A)}{2}\right) + \sqrt{\left(r_A + \frac{\delta\beta(1-r_A)}{2}\right)^2 + 2\delta^2 r_A \beta(1 - r_A)}}{2\delta r_A}.$$

Similarly,  $P(\gamma; \alpha)$  is strictly convex in  $\gamma$ . Under the parametric condition  $r_A < \frac{\delta\beta}{2(1+\delta)+\delta\beta}$ , it strictly follows that  $2(1 + \delta)r_A < \delta(\bar{r}_A - r_A)$ , and  $P(0; \alpha) < 0$ . Because  $P(1; \alpha) > 0$ ,  $P(\gamma; \alpha)$  has a unique positive root  $\gamma_I(\alpha)$  such that  $P < 0$  on  $(0, \gamma_I)$  and  $P > 0$  on  $(\gamma_I, \infty)$ . Denote

$$a_P \equiv 2\delta(r_A(1 - \alpha \bar{r}_A) + \bar{r}_A(1 - \alpha r_A)); \quad b_P \equiv \delta(r_A(1 - \alpha \bar{r}_A) + \bar{r}_A(1 - \alpha r_A) + 2r_A(1 - \alpha \bar{r}_A)^2);$$

$$c_P \equiv (1 - \alpha \bar{r}_A)^2(2(1 + \delta)r_A - \delta(\bar{r}_A - r_A)),$$

then

$$\gamma_I(\alpha) = \frac{-B_P + \sqrt{B_P^2 - 4A_P C_P}}{2A_P}.$$

We formally define  $\gamma^*(\alpha)$  as

$$\gamma^*(\alpha) = \begin{cases} \gamma_I(\alpha) & \text{if } \gamma_I(\alpha) < 1 - \alpha \bar{r}_A, \\ \gamma_N & \text{if } \gamma_I(\alpha) \geq 1 - \alpha \bar{r}_A. \end{cases}$$

## C Proposition 3

i. The threshold  $\gamma^*(\alpha)$  is defined in Appendix B as  $\min(\gamma_I(\alpha), \gamma_N)$ . Because  $\gamma_N$  is the root of  $N(\gamma) = 0$  and is independent of  $\alpha$ ,  $\frac{\partial \gamma_N}{\partial \alpha} = 0$ . We must show  $\frac{\partial \gamma_I}{\partial \alpha} < 0$  in the interior regime where  $\gamma^* = \gamma_I$ .

The threshold  $\gamma_I$  is the unique positive root of  $P(\gamma; \alpha) = 0$ . By the Implicit Function Theorem,  $\frac{\partial \gamma_I}{\partial \alpha} = -\frac{\partial P / \partial \alpha}{\partial P / \partial \gamma}$ . Because  $P(0; \alpha) < 0$  and  $P(\gamma_I; \alpha) = 0$ , the function crosses zero from below, implying  $\frac{\partial P}{\partial \gamma} > 0$  at  $\gamma_I$ . Differentiate  $P$  with respect to  $\bar{\sigma}$

$$\frac{\partial P}{\partial \bar{\sigma}} = 2\delta r_A \gamma (2\gamma - 1 - 2\bar{\sigma}) + 2\bar{\sigma} (2(1 + \delta)r_A - \delta\beta(1 - r_A)).$$

Under Condition (S), the bracketed constant is strictly negative. In the interior regime,  $\gamma_I < \bar{\sigma}$ , ensuring  $2\gamma_I - 1 - 2\bar{\sigma} < -1 < 0$ . Therefore, both terms are strictly negative, thus,  $\frac{\partial P}{\partial \bar{\sigma}} < 0$ . Since  $\bar{\sigma} = 1 - \alpha\bar{r}_A$ , we have  $\frac{\partial \bar{\sigma}}{\partial \alpha} = -\bar{r}_A < 0$ . Therefore,  $\frac{\partial P}{\partial \alpha} = \frac{\partial P}{\partial \bar{\sigma}} \frac{\partial \bar{\sigma}}{\partial \alpha} > 0$ . Consequently,  $\frac{\partial \gamma_I}{\partial \alpha} < 0$  and, thus,  $\frac{\partial \gamma^*}{\partial \alpha} \leq 0$ .

ii. The threshold  $\gamma^*(\alpha)$  is either  $\gamma_N$  or  $\gamma_I$ . Both roots share identical dependence on  $r_A$ , thus, evaluating root  $\gamma_N$  is sufficient to establish the comparative static: same implicit differentiation applies to  $P(\gamma; \alpha)$ .

Differentiate  $N$  with respect to  $r_A$

$$\frac{\partial N}{\partial r_A} = \delta\gamma^2 + \gamma + \frac{\delta\beta}{2}(1 - \gamma) > 0$$

Because  $N(\gamma)$  is convex and crosses zero from below,  $\frac{\partial N}{\partial \gamma} > 0$  at  $\gamma_N$ . Thus,  $\frac{\partial \gamma_N}{\partial r_A} = -\frac{\partial N / \partial r_A}{\partial N / \partial \gamma} < 0$ . An increase in baseline resentment  $r_A$  strictly increases the period 2 electoral penalty of current obstruction, amplifying the entrenchment effect. Thus,  $\frac{\partial \gamma^*}{\partial r_A} < 0$ .

iii. By i.  $\frac{\partial \gamma^*}{\partial \alpha} \leq 0$ . Thus  $\gamma^*(\alpha)$  is minimal at  $\alpha = 1$ . At this boundary  $\gamma^*(1) = \gamma_N$  and, thus,  $\gamma_N$  serves as the global lower bound for  $\gamma^*(\alpha)$ .

Because  $N(\gamma)$  is strictly convex with  $N(0) < 0$  and  $N(1) > 0$ , and  $\gamma^2 < \gamma$ ,  $N(\gamma)$  is strictly bounded by

$$N(\gamma) < r_A(1 + \delta)\gamma - \frac{\delta\beta(1 - r_A)}{2}(1 - \gamma).$$

The root of this upper bound bounds  $\gamma_N$ , thus

$$\gamma^*(\alpha) \geq \gamma_N > 1 - \frac{2(1 + \delta)r_A}{2r_A + \delta\beta(1 - r_A)}.$$

Note that  $2(1 + \delta)r_A > 2r_A$ , thus

$$\gamma^*(\alpha) \geq 1 - \frac{2(1 + \delta)r_A}{2r_A + \delta\beta(1 - r_A)}.$$

Note that RHS converges to 1 as  $r_A$  converges to 0, thus,  $\lim_{r_A \rightarrow 0} \gamma^*(\alpha) = 1$ .